

Big School Survey Shows More Preschoolers and More Suspensions

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Every few years, the U.S. government runs a big **survey** called the **Civil Rights** Data Collection. It shows how students are treated in public schools. The newest one covers the 2023-24 school year. It includes about 49.7 million students in more than 97,000 schools.

Two **researchers**, Maithreyi Gopalan and Dan Losen, studied the data and shared what they found with NPR.

More young kids went to **preschool**. About 1.5 million children were in public **preschool**, 12% more than in 2021-22.

More students were **suspended**, or sent out of school as a punishment. Students missed over 14 million school days this way. Losen said many suspensions are for small problems, like being late. He said helping students can work better.

The **survey** counted teachers by race for the first time since the 1970s. Teachers are 75% white, 9% Black and 11% Latino.

The government chose not to share data it collected about nonbinary students.

Word Treasure

survey -- A way to collect information by asking many people or places the same questions.

Civil Rights -- Rights that make sure every person is treated fairly and equally.

preschool -- A school for young children before kindergarten.

suspended -- Not allowed to go to school or class for a while as a punishment.

researchers -- People who study something carefully to learn new facts.

Background you need

The U.S. government collects information from public schools to check that all students are treated fairly.

Laws say schools cannot treat students unfairly because of their race, whether they are a boy or a girl, or a disability.

The results help leaders see where students may need more help.

Break it down

WHO: The U.S. government's survey, studied by researchers Maithreyi Gopalan and Dan Losen

WHAT: It found more kids in preschool, more suspensions and a teacher group that looks very different from students

WHERE: More than 97,000 public schools across the United States

WHY: To check whether students in public schools are treated fairly

Why it matters

The survey helps make sure kids like you are treated fairly at school.

Test what you remember

1. What is the big survey called?

- ☐ (A) The School Fun Report
- ☐ (B) The Preschool Count
- ☐ (C) The Teacher Test
- ☐ (D) The Civil Rights Data Collection

2. How many children were in public preschool?

- ☐ (A) About 1.5 million
- ☐ (B) About 97,000
- ☐ (C) About 75
- ☐ (D) About 14 million

3. What does suspended mean in this story?

- ☐ (A) Hanging from a rope
- ☐ (B) Given a prize
- ☐ (C) Moved to a new grade
- ☐ (D) Sent out of school as a punishment

4. How many school days did students miss because of suspensions?

- ☐ (A) About 100
- ☐ (B) Exactly 12
- ☐ (C) Over 14 million
- ☐ (D) About 1,970

5. What did Dan Losen say many suspensions are for?

- ☐ (A) Fire drills
- ☐ (B) Winning games
- ☐ (C) Good grades
- ☐ (D) Small problems, like being late

6. What share of teachers are white?

- ☐ (A) 19%
- ☐ (B) 11%
- ☐ (C) 75%
- ☐ (D) 9%

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: D 4: C 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Dan Losen: Says many suspensions are for small problems and that helping students can work better.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):